Resolving Conflict Within a Team

As we've discussed, differences in opinions and perspectives within a team is healthy and leads to creativity and innovation. However, with multiple people working closely together, it becomes even more important to have well-established protocol for handling disagreements, so that they lead to beneficial resolution rather than escalating conflict.

When a disagreement, misunderstanding, or conflict has arisen, address the steps to resolution, with these additional tips that are specific for working with teams.

- **Discuss the impact:** Bring the team together to discuss the impact the conflict is having on team dynamics and performance.
- **Agree to a cooperative process:** Everyone involved must agree to cooperate to resolve the conflict, including putting the team first.
- **Agree to communicate:** The most important aspect of resolving conflicts in teams is open communication. With so many people involved, misunderstandings are too easy when confusion or disagreements aren't worked out immediately.
- **Agree to listen:** Active listening is even more important for teams because truly understanding the thoughts and opinions of others is vital to working together toward common goals.
- **Clarify positions:** Whatever the conflict or disagreement, it's important to clarify people's positions. In collaborative groups, each team member is going to have their own perspective of a situation that is causing conflict. Each position needs to be clearly identified and articulated by those involved. This step alone can go a long way to resolve the conflict, as it helps the team hear all thoughts about a situation directly from the person who said them, rather than through word of mouth or gossip.
- **Analyze in smaller groups:** When different groups or factions within a team are in disagreement with each other, break teams into smaller groups and split up the individuals who are in alliance. It is easier for individuals to think outside of their own perspective when they do not have others constantly mirroring to them that they are right. Have the smaller groups dissect each position using the activity below. After analyzing the problem in small groups, bring the team back together and have a representative from each small group share the thoughts of their group.

Problem Solving Activity for Small Groups:

This activity works well for small teams or larger teams broken into small groups of 8 or less.

- First, brainstorm to identify the core problem that needs to be solved and the 2 to 4 main positions being taken. Remind the group that the goal is not to determine which position is correct and which is wrong, but rather to use the prevailing viewpoints as a starting point for gaining clarity and identifying possible solutions.
- Have the group analyze each position, looking for assumptions, objective facts, and any uncertainty that would warrant additional exploration and fact-finding. Also, have them make note of areas where the viewpoints overlap or have common ground. By considering what leads to other people's positions, the group will gain a better understanding of each other's

perspectives. This activity helps reveal areas of agreement and identify new ideas and solutions. For each position, have the team answer the following questions:

- What assumptions is this position making?
- Are they true? How do you know?
- If not, what impact is assuming having?
- What facts are being used as the core argument?
- Are they true? How do you know?
- If not, what impact is the misinformation having?
- What uncertainty, incongruence, or confusion exists?
- What additional information or facts are needed?
- What commonalities or overlap do you observe between these different positions?
- Where is there common ground or agreement?
- Are any solutions apparent?
- What else may be needed?

Reach a collective agreement: Now that all parties understand the others' positions, the team must decide how to move forward. Use the process presented in the course for brainstorming solutions. However, keep in mind that with a group, agreeing on a final position or solution is more challenging because of the varied points of view. In teams, it is necessary to discuss the importance of agreeing on a solution, even if each individual does not support it 100%.

The importance of team norms. The best approach to resolving disputes is to refer back to what team members have already agreed upon. This is why it is important to establish team norms through developing group guidelines or protocol, which include how to handle disagreements. This way, when conflicts are addressed in the group, the person bringing it to the attention of the group and the person facilitating the group discussion are not a) having to decide how to proceed in the moment or b) being blamed for bringing up the conflict. If you don’t have such an agreement for your team, bring the team together to work together on creating team norms and expectations. Have each team member sign the agreement Then, should conflicts arise, you can use the established guidelines to approach the situation, and should a new need be revealed, the team can decide to add a new rule of engagement to the agreement going forward.